



Spice

Part of the Spice Group, which has interests in telecom, BPO, retail, films and finance. It is among the oldest domestic mobile brands in India.

Price range Rs 2,000 to Rs 16,000

Competes against All big international and Indian brands

Reach A wide network of sales points and pan-India service centres

"We are paying attention to small details for the Indian consumer. The volume of sounds on our phones has been tripled given that the ambient sound levels in India are louder."

KUNAL AHOJA, CEO, Spice Mobile

loaded with music and video content.

Interestingly, Spice is the oldest indigenous mobile handset brand in India and has invested in distribution and after-sales service too over five years. Explains Kunal Ahooja, CEO of Spice Mobile: "We are paying attention to the smaller details when it comes to the Indian consumer. The volume of sounds on our phones has been tripled given that the ambient sound levels in India are louder. We realised that due to

multiple schemes offered by operators, Indians own several SIMs, so we launched a dual SIM phone." While Spice may have won the Golden Peacock award for its dual SIM phone in 2007, the record sales of such phones have even inspired competitors to launch phones with multiple SIM options. So much so that now companies are looking at launching a single phone which can accept CDMA and GSM SIM cards, simultaneously.

Five years ago the Indian consumer wasn't willing to try out an unknown Indian brand. But with Indian

companies offering localised content and features, the Indian brands are finally beginning to hit the right chord. As mobility makes its way into India's heartland, requirements from a mobile phone too have changed. A consumer in rural India may not be able to charge his phone as easily as one in a city, so the long battery life of 10 hours with active standby of 30 days is a big hit. Says Ramesh Vaswani, executive vice-chairman of Intex Mobiles: "We launched a dust and waterproof phone in 2008 making the phones more sturdy for the rural consumer."

The multinational players, due to their size, are not as nimble as the local players when it comes to launching new products. For instance, Nokia launched its first all weather-proof only late last year while the indigenous brands have attained this much faster. This is what makes Indian brands more appealing to the consumers who want innovations in record time. But it's important to watch out that none of the Indian companies manufacture their own phones and they all come from the factories of China and due to cut-throat competition, margins are wafer-thin. Ahooja believes this will cause a bloodbath in the market sometime soon, which will wash away many players. So are these phones worth the risk? Agarwal believes that consumers can opt for these phones if they want more for less money. However, when it comes to providing after-sales service and customer care, these "players are still getting there".

With the launch of 3G, rich features such as camera, Bluetooth and multimedia will become mainstream. The competitive pricing of the Indian players will only push the adoption of these technologies as India's telecom providers shift away from voice to data. The lowering of tariffs allowed Indians access to voice telephony. The mobile war will hopefully render smart phones cheaper and enable higher productivity and growth. ■

Videocon

Comes from the stable of consumer goods major Videocon Group

Price range Rs 1,400 to Rs 18,500

Competes against The biggest and the best Indian and mnc handset brands like Nokia, Samsung and LG in CDMA and GSM

Reach Plans afoot for a pan-India presence through a variety of retail networks by February

"Mobile phones are today an integral part of more than 500 million people and growing, and Videocon intends to be amongst the top three in this space in a year's time."

VENUGOPAL DHOOT, CMD Videocon Group



prices." **RAJIV AGARWAL**
CEO, THE MOBILE STORE